

Supplementary Material for *Biological positive controls for cross-cohort validation of prognostic gene expression, with a case study of EGFR in glioma*

Rishik Kondadadi^{1,2}

¹University of Minnesota

²Eastview High School

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This document is the supplementary material for the manuscript above. Every table and figure here is cited in the main text; numbering (S1, S2, ...) is continuous with those citations.

Supplementary Methods: Computational Environment

All analyses were performed in R version 4.6.0 (2026-04-24) on macOS Tahoe 26.5.1 (Darwin 25.5.1, aarch64-apple-darwin24.6.0). Key package versions: **TCGAbiolinks** 2.40.0 (Bioconductor), **SummarizedExperiment** 1.42.0 (Bioconductor), **DESeq2** 1.52.0 (Bioconductor; VST), **survival** 3.8-6 (CRAN; Cox models, Kaplan-Meier), **survminer** 0.5.2 (CRAN; survival plotting), **dplyr** 1.1.4, and **ggplot2** 3.5.1 (CRAN). Matrix operations used OpenBLAS 0.3.33 (BLAS) and R's internal LAPACK 3.12.1. Full session information is archived with the analysis scripts at <https://github.com/edanmn/TCGA-EGFR-Glioma>.

Supplementary Figures

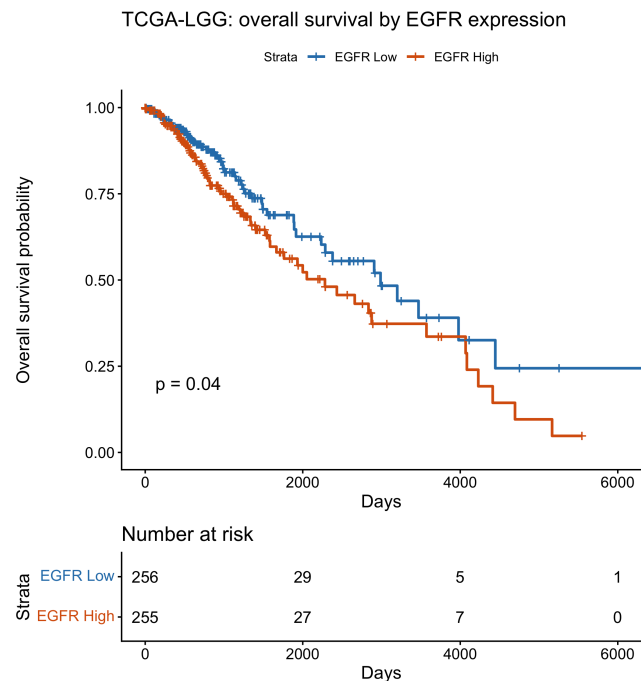


Figure S2. Unadjusted KM overall survival by EGFR group (median split), TCGA-LGG.

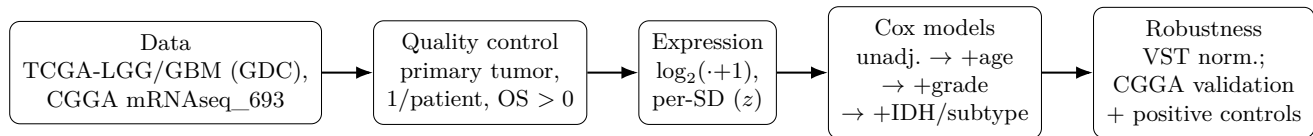


Figure S1. Analysis pipeline. Standardized expression enters nested Cox models with progressive confounder adjustment, followed by VST-normalization sensitivity and a positive-control-gated CGGA external-validation attempt. Acquisition is cached separately from analysis.

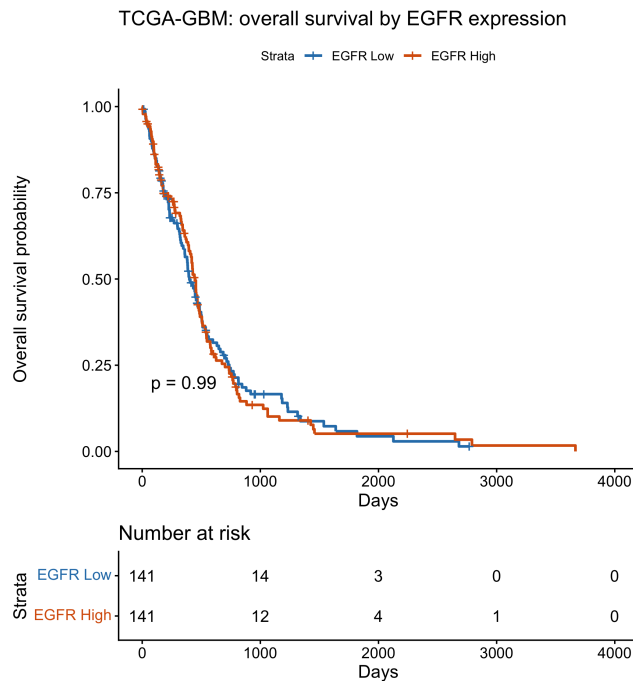


Figure S3. Unadjusted KM overall survival by EGFR group, TCGA-GBM.

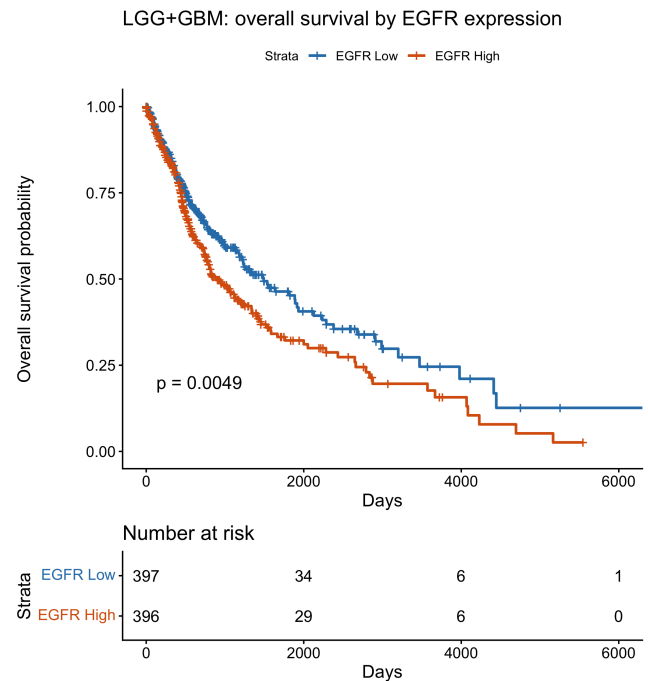


Figure S4. Unadjusted KM overall survival by EGFR group, pooled LGG+GBM.

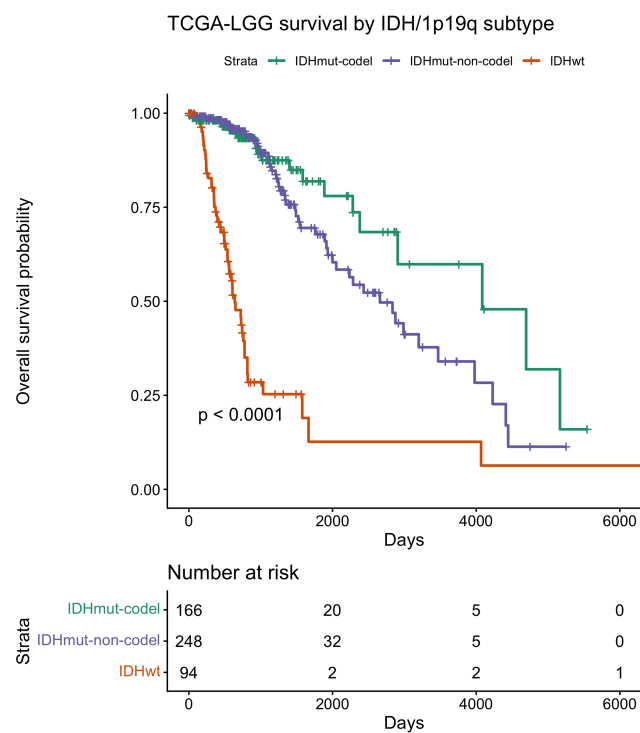


Figure S5. TCGA-LGG overall survival by IDH/1p19q molecular subtype; subtype, not EGFR, drives the separation in Figure S2.

Supplementary Tables

Table S1. Unadjusted Kaplan–Meier median-split results for EGFR in TCGA (descriptive).

Cohort	n low / high	Events	Median survival, low vs. high (days)	Log-rank p
TCGA-LGG	256 / 255	125	2,988 vs. 2,282	0.040
TCGA-GBM	141 / 141	227	399 vs. 448	0.99
Pooled (LGG+GBM)	397 / 396	352	1,491 vs. 883	4.85×10^{-3}

Table S2. FDR-controlled pathway screen in TCGA-LGG (HR per 1 SD, age-adjusted), with FDR-adjusted p before and after adding *IDH* status.

Gene	HR (95% CI), age-adjusted	p_{BH} (age)	p_{BH} (age + IDH)
RB1	1.64 (1.34–2.00)	1.59×10^{-5}	0.031
IDH1	1.46 (1.20–1.78)	8.67×10^{-4}	0.033
EGFR	1.37 (1.14–1.66)	3.54×10^{-3}	0.178
TP53	1.39 (1.13–1.71)	5.20×10^{-3}	0.026
PIK3R1	0.777 (0.649–0.931)	1.25×10^{-2}	0.876
PTEN	0.800 (0.666–0.961)	2.83×10^{-2}	0.506
CDKN2A	0.834 (0.691–1.01)	8.72×10^{-2}	0.046
PIK3CA	1.13 (0.950–1.34)	0.212	0.046
PDGFRA	0.893 (0.752–1.06)	0.220	0.594
NF1	0.895 (0.750–1.07)	0.222	0.085

Table S3. Normalization sensitivity: EGFR HR per 1 SD under DESeq2 VST (compare to the TPM results in Table 1).

Cohort	Model	HR (95% CI)	p	C-index
TCGA-LGG	Unadjusted	1.50 (1.22–1.84)	1.25×10^{-4}	0.577
TCGA-LGG	+ age, grade	1.26 (1.04–1.54)	0.020	0.784
TCGA-LGG	+ age, grade, IDH	1.11 (0.944–1.31)	0.205	0.829
TCGA-GBM	Unadjusted	0.945 (0.829–1.08)	0.397	0.524
TCGA-GBM	+ age, IDH	0.843 (0.737–0.963)	0.012	0.641

Table S4. Positive controls: Spearman correlation of gene expression with WHO grade in TCGA vs. CGGA.

EGFR (and the panel generally) tracks grade in TCGA but not CGGA, indicating attenuated expression–phenotype signal in the CGGA matrix. Correlations are computed on the same sample sets as Table 2, so the EGFR row matches that table exactly (+0.179 in TCGA, $n = 739$; -0.033 in CGGA-693, $n = 422$).

Gene	$r(\text{expression, grade})$, TCGA	$r(\text{expression, grade})$, CGGA
EGFR	+0.179	-0.033
IDH1	+0.348	+0.152
TP53	+0.099	+0.113
CDKN2A	-0.131	-0.076
NF1	-0.285	-0.183
PTEN	-0.357	-0.071
PDGFRA	-0.304	-0.096
PIK3R1	-0.481	-0.195
PIK3CA	-0.072	-0.057
RB1	-0.057	-0.023

Table S5. Pipeline robustness: nested EGFR Cox models (HR per 1 SD) on TCGA re-obtained from recount3 (independent Monorail raw-read reprocessing). Estimates match the GDC-pipeline results (Table 1).

Cohort	Model	HR (95% CI)	p	n / events
TCGA-LGG	Unadjusted	1.54 (1.25–1.89)	4.02×10^{-5}	509 / 125
TCGA-LGG	+ age, grade	1.27 (1.04–1.55)	0.021	452 / 106
TCGA-LGG	+ age, grade, IDH	1.11 (0.94–1.31)	0.220	450 / 105
TCGA-GBM	Unadjusted	0.906 (0.755–1.09)	0.289	154 / 122
TCGA-GBM	+ age	0.853 (0.712–1.02)	0.084	154 / 122
TCGA-GBM	+ age, grade, IDH	0.813 (0.677–0.977)	0.027	150 / 120

Table S6. Positive-control-gated cross-cohort replication for genes prognostic in TCGA (FDR < 0.05), among 500 top-variable genes, in two cohort pairs that share no patients. Replication is far higher for QC-concordant (grade-concordant) than QC-discordant (grade-discordant) genes; Fisher exact $p < 10^{-20}$ for both pairs. Both sign-flips observed in the panel fall among QC-discordant genes, though with only two such events this is suggestive rather than decisive.

Cohort pair	Positive control	Genes	Replicated % (95% CI)
TCGA → CGGA-693	QC-concordant	429	92.8 (89.9–95.0)
TCGA → CGGA-693	QC-discordant	37	24.3 (11.8–41.2)
TCGA → CGGA-325	QC-concordant	439	95.4 (93.1–97.2)
TCGA → CGGA-325	QC-discordant	26	19.2 (6.6–39.4)

Table S7. Circularity control (TCGA → CGGA-693, grade-anchor QC; bootstrap 95% CIs). The QC’s predictive value is partly inflated by grade-correlated genes but persists for subtype-independent associations (grade+IDH-adjusted) and low-grade-correlation genes, excluding a purely tautological explanation. This control uses the TCGA∩CGGA-693 gene universe (6,616 prognostic genes) rather than the four-cohort intersection used for the headline analysis (6,512 genes; Table 4), which is why n , the replication rate, and the AUC differ slightly from Table 4.

Prognostic-gene set	Genes	Replication rate	AUC (95% CI)
Unadjusted (age only)	6,616	0.63	0.82 (0.81–0.83)
Subtype-adjusted (grade + IDH)	183	0.23	0.65 (0.55–0.74)
Low grade-correlation ($ r < 0.2$)	935	0.51	0.75 (0.72–0.78)
High grade-correlation ($ r \geq 0.2$)	5,681	0.65	0.84 (0.83–0.85)

Table S8. Naive CGGA external-validation models: EGFR HR per 1 SD in primary tumors. Retained for transparency only; these estimates are *not* interpretable, because CGGA EGFR expression fails the positive control (Table 2, Table S4, Figure 1). The apparent IDH-adjusted and treatment-adjusted effects are artifacts of EGFR mis-measurement in CGGA, not evidence of a prognostic effect.

Cohort	Model	HR (95% CI)	p	C-index
CGGA II/III	Unadjusted	1.17 (0.938–1.46)	0.164	0.520
CGGA II/III	+ age, grade	1.19 (0.958–1.48)	0.115	0.624
CGGA II/III	+ age, grade, IDH	1.44 (1.17–1.76)	4.6×10^{-4}	0.737
CGGA II/III	+ treatment (sens.)	1.37 (1.09–1.71)	6.8×10^{-3}	0.743
CGGA IV	+ age, IDH	1.12 (0.919–1.35)	0.268	0.594

Table S9. TCGA cohort characteristics and covariate availability after quality control. *IDH* status is available for 508 (LGG) and 265 (GBM) patients and molecular subtype for 508 and 257; counts sum to the cohort total including the unknown category. The grade row counts patients with a *recorded* histologic grade; all TCGA-GBM patients are treated as WHO grade IV by study definition, and one lacks a recorded grade field. Sex was not populated in the expression-object annotation.

Characteristic	TCGA-LGG	TCGA-GBM
Histologic grade	II–III	IV
Patients	511	282
Deaths (events)	125	227
Median age, years (IQR)	41 (32–53)	60 (51–69)
<i>IDH</i> (Mutant / WT / unknown)	414 / 94 / 3	21 / 244 / 17
Subtype (codel / non-codel / wt)	166 / 248 / 94	— / 19 / 238
Histologic grade recorded	454	281